

When the mighty fell

Ilia Topuria and Alex Pereira entered as champions but left stunned as the titans lost to Justin Gaethje and Ciry! Gane in a night of **seismic upsets.**

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'El Matador. 18-0'

This was Ilia Topuria's *Instagram* bio ahead of his fight against Justin Gaethje at UFC Freedom 250, which took place at the White House. Undefeated in his professional MMA career spanning 17 fights, Topuria was so confident of victory that he pre-empted the result and added one more win to his record even before stepping into the Octagon.

The odds, too, were in his favour. He won the featherweight title, moved up to lightweight and captured that belt as well within six months. He had registered three consecutive knockout wins and was brimming with confidence.

However, those hopes came crashing down once he stepped into the cage on June 15.

Gaethje pulled off a monumental upset (**above, first**), snapping Topuria's undefeated streak to claim the undisputed lightweight title via

fourth-round corner stoppage.

Topuria opened with sharp, accurate boxing, but an early Gaethje hook opened a severe laceration above his right eye.

Topuria adjusted brilliantly in the next round, unleashing constant body attacks. He dropped Gaethje with a devastating left hook to the liver, advanced to full mount and hunted for an armbar.

However, this emphasis on grappling provided Gaethje with an opportunity to survive. By the third round, Topuria's frenetic pace had caused a significant slowdown.

Gaethje capitalised, using heavy right hands and an uppercut to shatter Topuria's defence and inflict an orbital fracture. Though Topuria fought fiercely through the fourth round, his severely swollen eye and compromised vision forced his corner to throw in the towel.

"Justin, congratulations. You said you'd leave your mark on my face...

and you did. You took the sight from my right eye in the first round, and by the end of the second, from my left too," Topuria said in a statement after the fight. "I had one of the best camps of my life. I came in sharp, prepared and ready. Last night was your night," he added.

The rest of the UFC Freedom 250 main card matched the chaos of the main event, delivering a historic 100 per cent finish rate. The theme of shocking upsets continued in the co-main event, where Ciry! Gane reclaimed the interim heavyweight title by stopping heavy favourite Alex Pereira via second-round TKO (**above, second**).

Much like Topuria, Pereira had been heavily backed to dictate the terms, but Gane's tactical movement completely neutralised "Poatan". Together, Gaethje and Gane shattered the odds, producing two of the biggest championship upsets the sport has seen in recent years.



Did you know?

While Gaethje made Topuria's vision blurry with his devastating blows, he himself had struggled with similar issues in the past. For the first 17 fights of his professional career, Gaethje competed with severe visual impairment. Former fighters noted that he routinely had to make physical contact with opponents just to gauge distance accurately and know what he was hitting. He finally underwent corrective eye surgery in 2016, just before his explosive UFC debut against Michael Johnson.